



As the Diary trudged through the horde towards the mixed zone to get a reaction from the players, Ajaraie was spotted gesturing to a couple of young fans, giving a thumbs up and placing his hand to his heart, promising to fulfil their wish of taking a picture with him.

He kept his word and then went around the crowd, skimming through phones, taking picture after picture until all were content.

In return, Ajaraie was comforted with words of encouragement. "Don't worry about today's result. We will be here to back you for the next two games as well," the fans said.

With a heartfelt smile, he disappeared into the team bus. After all, football is for the fans as much as it is for the players.

Joan Mathew Jacob

Manjappada mania

A derby is an eventful day in the football calendar. If it is a Southern Derby between Chennaiyin FC and

Kerala Blasters, one can expect a feisty atmosphere not just inside the ground during the match but also outside, leading up to the clash.

As the Diary made way towards the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium, fans adorned in Chennaiyin Blue and Blasters Yellow dominated the streets, and there was, of course, the banter that one would expect ahead of a derby. Extra police personnel were deployed to ensure that the verbal banter did not escalate.

As expected, the Manjappada presence was strong, and despite being the away team, they seemed to be the louder fan base going into the match. It wasn't long into the match before their cheers grew louder and the Chennaiyin crowd fell silent, as Jesus Jimenez opened the scoring in the third minute.

Korou Singh Thingujam and Kwame Peprah (**above, centre**) also found the net to complete the thrashing before Vincy Barretto pulled one back late in the match,

with the contest finishing 3-1 in the Blasters' favour.

But the contest wasn't devoid of controversy. First, Wilmar Jordan Gil's red card in the 37th minute became a major talking point, with Chennaiyin head coach Owen Coyle calling the decision a "travesty" and engaging in a public dispute with commentator and former Indian footballer Robin Singh during the post-match presentation ceremony.

Blasters might have won the derby but finished the contest on a bitter note, as captain Adrian Luna got involved in a physical altercation with teammate Noah Sadaoui after the latter refused to pass the ball to him and went for goal himself.

However, that incident remained secondary to Kerala fans, who left the stadium with the boasting rights, and their chants directed towards their Chennaiyin counterparts were indication enough of the rivalry that exists between the teams.

Aneesh Dey